that it was not prudent to remain where he was in such a time of turmoil and unrest, he remained firm and refused to leave.' It is easy to imagine Jagat Gosain's concern for the well-being of her son. She had been separated from him all his life, as he had been entrusted to Ruqaiya Begum. Now, as the possibility of reclaiming him became a reality at last, his life appeared to be in danger. Rumours of poisonings and assassinations spread among the courtiers and the townsfolk, and people began distancing themselves from the dying Padshah. Khurram was commanded to present himself before his parents, which he did, but then told them 'as long as there is a breath of life left in my grandfather, there is no possibility of my being separated from him'.

Raja Man Singh, meanwhile, continued in his efforts to eliminate Salim as a contender for the throne. He tried to have the prince arrested when Salim came by boat to Agra Fort but, alerted, Salim was able to evade his would-be captors and sailed back down the Yamuna to his haveli. The raja then gathered the powerful noblemen at court within one of the halls of the palace and made an impassioned speech asking them to support Khusrau against his violent and unpredictable father. But the other nobles demurred, led by Sayyid Khan Baraha, who had long been a supporter of Salim, and Shaikh Farid, the mir bakshi. They said, among other things, 'that to give the throne to a son during the lifetime of his father was not in keeping with tradition, particularly the canons and customs of the Chagtai clan from which the Mughal royal family was descended'.

Day by day Akbar's health continued to fail. Hakim Ali's medicines worsened his condition and the Padshah was finally unable to rise from his bed, even to attend the daily darshan. It was at this stage that the Jesuits went to see Akbar, hoping for a deathbed renunciation of all his religious wrongs and a final acceptance of Christianity. As they entered his chambers they were convinced that they would find the emperor moribund, penitent, keen to make his peace with Jesus Christ and embrace the Lord. 'But they found him,' they wrote in amazement, 'amongst his captains, and in so cheerful and merry a mood, that they deemed the time unsuitable for speaking to him of the end of his life, and decided to await another opportunity. They came away, fully persuaded that he was making good progress, and that rumour, as ordinarily happens when kings are sick, had exaggerated the seriousness of his malady.'